

Florence Cathedral

A masterpiece of Renaissance architecture with a soaring dome that dominates the skyline of the city of Florence



S. Europe

In 1296, the citizens of Florence, then a wealthy and independent city-state in Tuscany, announced a plan to build a cathedral, “an edifice ... so magnificent in its height and quality that it shall surpass anything of its kind produced ... by the Greeks and the Romans.” The chosen architect, Arnolfo di Cambio (c.1240–1310), designed a building on an impressive scale, with massive pillars along the nave supporting an arched stone roof. At the east end, a vast octagonal space was to be capped by a dome. Unfortunately, although the ancient Romans had built large domes, their engineering knowledge had been lost with the passage of time.

Reviving Classical knowledge

Florence Cathedral remained unfinished for over a century, until the task was handed to architect Filippo Brunelleschi (1377–1446). True to the

spirit of the Renaissance—the rediscovery of the learning of the ancient world—Brunelleschi traveled to study the ruins of ancient Rome. He returned to Florence primed to begin work on the dome in 1420. The result, declared complete in 1436, was a triumph of engineering, as well as a thing of beauty. The dome was subsequently topped by a stone lantern, designed by Brunelleschi but completed after his death by his follower Michelozzo.

The interior of the cathedral is austere, but the exterior is decorated with bands of colored marble, matching the nearby Giotto Campanile and Florence Baptistery. The church’s extremely elaborate facade is a 19th-century addition. The Cattedrale di Santa Maria del Fiore, as it is formally known, is at the center of a UNESCO World Heritage Site and is one of the world’s most visited tourist attractions.



△ CATHEDRAL CLOCK

A one-handed clock inside the cathedral measured time from sunset to sunset. The clock face was painted by Paolo Uccello (1397–1475).

The **cathedral dome** spans **138 ft (42 m)** and rises to **374 ft (114 m)** above the ground

▽ BAPTISTERY CEILING

The octagonal Baptistery standing next to the cathedral has a richly decorated interior. The mosaics on the ceiling date from the 13th century.

BRUNELLESCHI'S DOME

The dome of Florence Cathedral is constructed on an octagonal base. From this rises a lightweight skeleton of stone ribs, over which an inner and an outer skin are laid, chiefly of brick. The lantern, plugging a 20-ft (6-m) hole at the top of the dome, helps to hold it together, as well as adding to the height.

